

Winding Tree

On a journey to a Decentralized Marketplace

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INTRO

The goal of this article is to explain the ongoing processes within the Winding Tree project. We will cover the future of travel, Líf Token, WIN as a brand, partnerships, the DAO and more. We are on a journey to create a decentralised marketplace which will disrupt not just the travel industry, but also other marketplaces/industries which are burdened with unjustified and overinflated intermediary fees.

ON A JOURNEY

Thanks to *Mathieu Tahon*, *NTL*, *Rob Speirs* for their contribution to this article.

But before we go on, a quick reminder of who we are. Winding Tree is a *nonprofit* organization building *public goods* the way of *open-source* technologies and regenerative marketplaces. Our **vision** is to bring innovative solutions into the travel industry, providing a platform for travellers and vendors to engage in regenerative travel programmes. Our **mission** is to directly connect travellers and vendors on a decentralized marketplace without intermediaries.

What is the difference between Intermediary and IT Providers → coming soon.

We hear how huge and positively impactful these technological and mental shifts can be for both sides. Therefore we have to deal not only with blockchain itself, but also with existing business processes, legal restrictions, financial regulations, and lack of knowledge and habits: *it's a challenging but worthwhile adventure.*

So we ask, will you join us on this journey?

WIN PILOT SAVED 20 000 EUROS

In April 2022, when pandemic restrictions were getting loosened, Winding Tree created a unique Web3 travel experience for the Devconnect conference in Amsterdam. Attendees were able to book rooms in a hotel through Metamask with xDai and to check in with NFTs. This proof-of-concept helped us to save 20,000 Euros for the Ethereum community.

The process for travellers was very straightforward with **no need to provide any personal data or credit card number** to the platform:

1. Visit win.so.
2. Choose a room.
3. Connect your wallet.
4. Sign the transaction.
5. Receive an NFT in your MetaMask wallet.
6. Show the NFT at the front desk to check-in.

But the process for us to connect with the vendor was a bit more challenging, mildly put. We partnered with DoubleTree by Hilton. It is a perfect hotel to stay when in Amsterdam. The location was especially convenient for the Devconnect attendees as it was a 10-minute walk through the beautiful streets of the old town.

To have this pilot fly we had to:

1. To block rooms in the hotel.
2. Configure the rooms as an on-chain inventory.
3. Educate the front desk staff on the NFT check-in process.
4. Promote the win.so among the attendees of the conference.
5. Support both the travellers and receptionists during the check-in.

Despite the long onboarding process, we were inspired by the impressive soft launch. From that point, the team focused on upcoming events in Paris (ETHcc) and Barcelona (EthBarcelona). Through these events is when we encountered **real challenges**.

CHALLENGES

Inventory

Based on the Amsterdam experience and other events we learned a lesson. It takes a lot of time and effort to not only convince a hotelier to experiment with new technologies but also implement them. Both independent hotels and big chains are overloaded with work (especially after borders are open) and are not ready for another solution; at least not without a clear tangible profit proven by numbers. This is just business, nothing personal. We heard this on numerous calls with potential global partners. We heard this from local hoteliers in Amsterdam and Barcelona during the workshops we organised.

But the biggest blocker for vendors is the fact, that at the moment on-chain inventory can not be synchronized with Property Management Systems (PMS). The whole process takes too much time and human resources both from the side of the hotel and from the Winding Tree team. These experiments in Amsterdam, Barcelona and Paris showed, that the block-room approach is not scalable as we can not block rooms throughout the year for all hotels in the world.

SIMARD

Therefore Winding Tree partnered with Simard. This company is an IT Provider but also has a Travel Agency accreditation with IATA and has built direct and indirect connections with many travel suppliers. Thanks to its status as a Travel Agency, Simard has access through Intermediaries to commissionable rates from 300 000+ hotels globally. These connections are utilised in the most effective and sustainable way. Moreover, Simard is already helping large corporations to join the Winding Tree marketplace.

This partnership enabled fast access to the funnel of content. Right now, we have over 300,000 hotels in 100 countries available on the dApp (decentralized application). All the hotels can be booked through smart contracts on the **Gnosis** and **Polygon** chains. Additionally, the contracts accept 10+ stablecoins reflecting their local currencies.

Demand

To stimulate demand, we first needed to define a target audience. For us, Web3 communities seemed to be the most accessible and relevant (at this point in time). Thus, we focused on creating connections and partnering with blockchain conferences and events worldwide. This strategy has worked to an extent but has its pros and cons. Thus, by building a new brand we look at a wider audience of travellers who care about people, destinations and our planet.

WIN BRAND

Thanks to blockchain technology WIN is geared to give back to travellers, vendors, and communities. We've already implemented one such measure: Toucan Protocol's NCT token. After successful bookings users can choose to be rewarded Líf tokens or NCT tokens. These tokens allow a certain amount of CO2 to be retired on the behalf of the traveller. After checking out from a hotel booked at beta.win.so a digital certificate is created for the traveller.

The long-term goal is to have community funds for each region we travel to, where we'll get to vote on what local projects treasury funds will be used for. In the meantime, we plan to partner with an established international charity and agree on an ongoing charitable donation that would be made as the platform grows.

Eventually, we need to organically build out local cooperatives that would manage local funds; so, partnering with an already established charity would help us lay foundations for the future DAOs.

Building a **strong and reliable brand** takes time. We believe in our mission and invite you to join the journey of building a new platform for regenerative travel.

Crypto payments

WIN plans to spark a new wave of mass adoption for crypto payments. The travel industry is massive and now most of the tickets or confirmations are digital. If we have digital documents, we need to have a wider range of digital payments. Available now are 10+ stablecoins that travellers can use on the platform.

What is a stablecoin? → coming soon.

The plan is to make the process of payment accessible and simple. To achieve this goal we built WIN as a multichain platform with bridges and various wallets available for travellers. Thanks to integrations with Ramp Network, Mt Pelerin, Coinbase Pay, and other services, the onramping process will be smooth.

INTEGRATIONS

Any journey is a process. We experiment, make mistakes, analyse them and then move on. Among the upcoming destinations of our collective journey, we see many partnerships. The first two are IT providers (not intermediaries) which will allow Winding Tree to build direct connections with vendors. These are a switch and a PMS:

- **Derbysoft** (a switch);
- **Mews** (a PMS).

What is the difference between a SWITCH and PMS → coming soon.

It's going to be game-changing. WIN will finally get direct connections since Simard, Derbysoft and Mews are just IT providers in this setup, not

“intermediaries”. Hotel Brands will be able to have their own **ORGiDs** with the “plumbing” they have chosen. It means, they will know for sure what Winding Tree is building and see how this technology will change the industry.

We should keep in mind that such a partnership is just the first step towards direct connections. Despite the fact that both Derbysoft and Mews work with hundreds of brands, in order to get this content on our platform, we will have to **sign contracts with each and every brand**. It may take much more time than just going through intermediaries. But, the game is worth the candle. It will get us to the next station of our journey.

Some of you may ask: “If you can build direct connections, why do you need intermediaries?”

This intermediary step is dictated by the rules of the industry. Despite the positive feedback we receive about both Winding Tree and WIN on numerous calls with vendors, in order to sign any contract and build direct partnerships, they want to see a certain threshold of transactions on a platform. That is what we are working on — the demand.

PEER-TO-PEER

With the growth of transactions on the platform, we will be able to attract big brands and individual accommodation providers to the platform. This is the time when Líf token will get its move. Depending on the way Winding Tree will function by that moment, the possible utilities for holders may be:

- invitation to a vendor referral program (Líf holders onboard hotels and get rewards);
- invitation to a traveller referral program (Líf holders onboard travellers and get rewards);
- special offers and deals program for Líf holders;
- events and activities for Líf holders;

- others

When this becomes clear, we will begin discussions about listing the token in a CEX or DEX.

As Mark Cuban puts it: “I have said from day 1, the value of a token is derived from the applications that run on its platform and the utility they create.”

DAO

When the product, protocol, token and community are aligned, we will be able to make more certain steps into a structure of a DAO. And what is more important, there will be clear reasons and purposes for it. Until then we will be growing and engaging our community by means of WIPs, calls, polls, partnerships, and other activities to build bonds and move forward to the decentralized future.

Come and embark on this journey with us!

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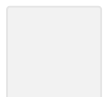
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Responses (1)



Maksim Izmaylov

What are your thoughts?



Rob Speirs

Nov 15, 2022



This proof-of-concept helped us to save 20,000 Euros for the Ethereum community.

Still crazy to think this how much was saved. I wonder over 1 year how much the cost savings will be.



1

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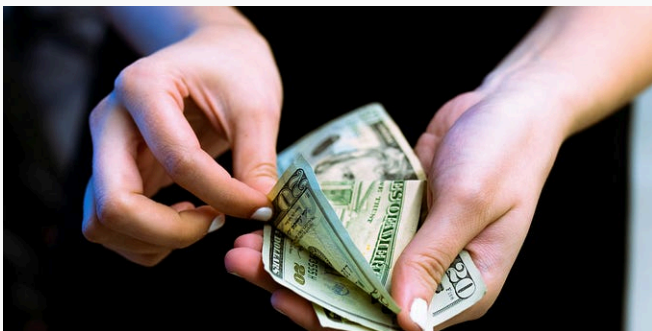


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